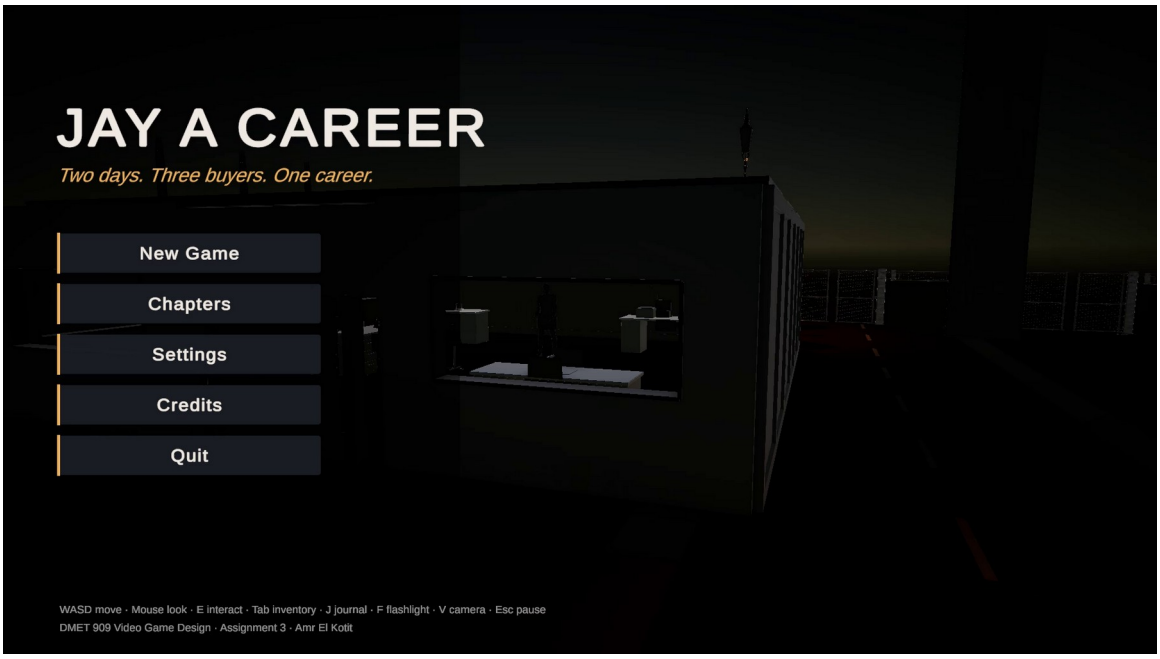
Jay A Career

Game Design Document — Assignment 3: Storyline, Levels and UI

Amr Hazem El Kotit · 58-14399 · DMET 909 Video Game Design · GUC · Winter 2026



Main menu: the live game world at dusk behind the menu.

Repository: https://github.com/amrelkotit/Jay-A-Career/tree/assignment-3
Prototype Video: *VGD Assignment 3.mp4 (2:53, submitted with this document); full 12-minute playthrough in the repository under Video/*

Unity 6000.3.24f1 · URP · branch assignment-3 · open Assets/JayACareer/Scenes/MainMenu.unity and press Play.

Status (6 November 2026, revision 3): the prototype is complete and playable from the main menu to the end screen, and an automated playthrough verifies every beat, flag and transition in all three branches. Revision 3 tightens the story to two days (Leo and Luka on Day 1, Paul on Day 2), makes Trust and Heat change what Hale and Paul say and pay, and lights the counter for the night scenes (log in §9).

Contents: 1 Storyline · 2 Characters · 3 Narrative Structure · 4 Levels · 5 UI Design · 6 Implementation Plan · 7 Art & Audio · 8 Story in the Prototype · 9 Implementation Notes, Revisions & Credits

1. Storyline Summary

Jay A Career is a grounded, story-driven crime drama played from a first- or third-person view across two days in Calder Flats, a fictional dying desert town. The tone is quiet and tense: the danger comes from conversations, money and silence rather than combat. The core conflict is survival against loyalty. Jay, a broke twenty-three-year-old, finds an eviction notice on his door: $400 in two days or he loses his room. The only job on offer is across the road, in the rented laboratory of Dr. Elias Hale, a former industrial chemist the town gossips about but never visits.

Hale's rules are simple: seal the order at the preparation bench, carry the tamper-sealed carton across the road to the collection counter, take the money, clean the bench and say nothing. The product is never named or shown; every character simply calls it "the order". On the first morning the buyer is Leo, a nervous regular who pays $100 in small bills and, if Jay asks who else buys, lets a name slip: Paul. Asking gets Jay noticed. In Hale's desk Jay finds an old Corvane Industrial Chemicals staff badge with Hale's photo scratched out. Hale was somebody once.

The same evening Hale has a second order, and he is nervous about it. As dusk falls Luka, a sharp middleman, makes his offer. This is the game's meaningful choice: accept Luka's $150, push for $250, or refuse him entirely. Each option changes Jay's cash, Hale's Trust and the attention (Heat) on the operation. A message on Luka's phone, signed only "P.", reveals that someone bigger is watching the old man's new boy, and Jay decides whether to tell Hale or keep it to himself.

The second day ends in darkness. At midnight, with the rent due at dawn, Hale's lights are off and his coat is still on the hook. With a flashlight Jay finds a ledger of eight years of payments to "P.", an unsent letter to Hale's daughter and a lockbox holding a $480,000 settlement. Hale returns and confesses: he took the blame for a colleague's accident at Corvane, lost his licence, and Paul bought the debt. How much he says depends on Trust; a

Hale who trusts Jay presses $100 into his hand for the rent. Then Paul arrives, calm and polite, already knowing about the Luka deal. His price depends on Heat: $250 for a quiet newcomer, $150 for a loud one. He slides a card across the counter: "Tomorrow. Without the old man." Jay may have his rent. He no longer has a simple answer: whose career is this?

> *Story spine (lecture practice): Jay needs $400 in two days, so he takes a delivery job from Dr. Hale, a disgraced chemist. On the first day he serves two buyers, and the second one, Luka, carries a message signed "P." that shows someone is watching. Because of that, Jay searches Hale's dark lab the next night and learns that Hale has been paying Paul for eight years. Until finally Paul offers Jay the job without Hale, and Jay must decide whose career this is.*

2. Character Profiles

Profiles follow the lecture's Character Background Paper, Character Attributes (characterization and status), archetypes, Character Audio Design (voice) and Character Dimensions (growth). Portraits are rendered from the in-game models and appear in the dialogue box.



Jay — protagonist (player avatar)

Background: 23, grew up in Calder Flats, dropped out of technical college and lives on odd jobs. Quick, sarcastic when nervous, honest underneath.

Motivation: Keep his room and prove he is more than "the kid who never finished anything". Fear: ending up exactly where he started.

Role and relation to the player: The player is Jay; every choice is his. Hero's Journey arc: ordinary world (eviction) → call (Hale's job) → threshold (first carton) → tests (Luka) → revelation (Hale's notes) → reward and new dilemma (Paul's card).

Archetype, voice and growth: Character, not avatar (lecture): he has opinions and emotions. Voice: short sentences, dry jokes when nervous. Growth: from "I need the rent" to "whose career is this?". Status attributes on the HUD: Cash, Trust, Heat, Day.



Dr. Elias Hale — mentor

Background: 58, former senior chemist at Corvane Industrial Chemicals. Took the blame for a colleague's accident, lost his job and licence, and now runs a small rented lab.

Motivation: Pay off the settlement Paul owns, keep Paul away from his life and, one day, reconnect with his daughter Clara. Fear: ruining someone else's life a second time.

Role and relation to the player: Mentor. Teaches Jay, hides the truth, then confesses in Level 3. His Trust is a HUD meter the player moves; at high Trust he tells everything and gives Jay $100 for the rent, at low Trust he holds back.

Archetype, voice and growth: Archetype: Magician (wise mentor) with his shadow, the Manipulator. Voice: formal vocabulary, complete sentences, never swears. Visual elements: lab coat on the hook,

cracked award. Growth: secrecy → confession.



Leo — buyer, Level 1

Background: Thirties, grey hoodie, hands in pockets. Jittery, polite, talks too much and pays in small bills.
Motivation: Get his order and leave before anyone important notices him.
Role and relation to the player: Tutorial buyer: a safe first deal that teaches the hand-off. Narrative hook: lets the name "Paul" slip (optional question).
Archetype, voice and growth: Supporting NPC whose nervous chatter breaks up the monotony while revealing information. Voice: fast, apologetic, repeats himself. Visual: grey hoodie, hands in pockets.



Luka — buyer, Level 2

Background: Late twenties, red jacket, confident and impatient; charming until he is not.
Motivation: Collect cheaply for his boss and test the new boy.
Role and relation to the player: Middleman and the meaningful choice. His phone reveals that "P." is watching Jay.
Archetype, voice and growth: Archetype: Warrior in his shadow form (the bully). Voice: mocking, rhetorical questions ("So? We doing this?"). Visual: red jacket, the only strong colour at dusk.



Paul — buyer, Level 3

Background: Fifties, shaved head, dark waistcoat over an open collar, very still. Calm, polite and patient; never threatens directly.
Motivation: Keep Hale in debt and recruit Jay without him.
Role and relation to the player: Antagonist and climax. Reacts to how Jay treated Luka and to Heat (he pays $250, $200 or $150 for the carton), then delivers the cliffhanger offer.
Archetype, voice and growth: Archetype: King in his shadow form, the Tyrant. Voice: slow, polite, never raised. Visual: still posture, waistcoat, headlights behind him. Growth: none; he is the fixed point the others orbit.

3. Narrative Structure

The plot uses the lecture's three-act Story Units: Act 1 hook (Level 1), Act 2 hold (Level 2), Act 3 payoff (Level 3). Each act is broken into sequences, scenes and beats (beat table, §6.1). On the lecture's Story Phases curve: intro (cutscene, briefing), complication (Leo lets "Paul" slip; the scratched-out badge), body (Luka's deal, the "P." message, the dark lab), climax

(Hale's confession and Paul's offer), resolution (Jay holding the card) and point (whose career is this?). Content is revealed through the three lecture methods: challenges or choices (Luka), the journey (crossing the road each day) and drama, as time passes from morning to midnight.

Story events use all three Week 7 categories: player-triggered (talking, picking up clues, the choice), system-driven (dusk falling and the lamps switching on, the phone buzzing) and authored (the cutscenes and Hale's return). Branching follows the foldback (branch-and-bottleneck) structure from the Week 7 lecture: the Luka choice branches into three outcomes that reconverge at Paul, but the branch keeps paying off in later content — Hale's reaction, the recap between levels, Hale's confession, Paul's opening line, the final cash and the end-screen summary. Objectives always come from the story state, so the dramatic tension curve rises steadily: morning safety, dusk pressure, night danger.

Level	Emotional arc	Key plot points
Level 1	Desperation → relief → curiosity	Eviction notice; easy money from Leo; Hale's scratched-out badge.
Level 2	Pressure → agency → unease	Luka's offer; the player's choice; the "P." message as the street lamps flicker on.
Level 3	Dread → empathy → shock	Dark lab search; Hale's confession; Paul's calm offer and the card.

Hero's Journey stage	In Jay A Career
Ordinary world / call	Eviction notice; Hale's job offer (L1 intro and briefing)
Crossing the threshold	Sealing and delivering the first carton to Leo
Tests, allies, enemies	Luka's deal; the "P." message (L2)
Ordeal / revelation	Searching Hale's lab; the confession (L3)
Reward and new challenge	Paul's money and the card: "Tomorrow. Without the old man."

3.1 Dialogue design

Dialogue design follows the lecture's "Dialogue: Games" rules: every line must reveal information, reveal character, or break up the monotony, and it must connect to the plot. Revision 2 removed or rewrote every line that did none of these (for example Hale's "Sit down. No, stand." and Jay's end-of-day remark about the street lights). Lines show rather than tell, and each conversation has preconditions and actions (lecture: "More than Just Talk").

Conversation	Purpose (reveal information / character / break monotony)	Precondition	Action
Hale's briefing	Information: the rules, the first buyer; character: Hale's precision	Day 1, first talk	briefingDone; preparation unlocked
Hale at his desk / badge	Information: Hale worked at Corvane; mystery	badge picked up	badgeFound; journal entry
Leo's deal	Character: nervous runner; information: "Hale never hires anyone"	carton on the counter	+$100 (numeric action)
Leo's slip (optional)	Information: the name Paul	player asks "Who else buys?"	journal entry; Heat +1
Hale's evening news	Information: a second buyer tonight; character: Hale is nervous	bench cleaned (Day 1)	haleEvening → act1Complete
Hale's warning	Information: Luka collects for someone; sets up the choice	Day 1 evening, first talk	lukaWarned
Luka's deal (choice)	Character: Luka the bully; the choice	carton on the counter	lukaDeal; cash, trust, heat
Luka's outcome lines	Feedback on the choice; points to the phone	choice made	phone becomes a clue
Hale's reaction + tell or keep "P."	Character: Hale's values (3 variants); Jay's honesty (choice)	Luka dealt with; phone read	haleReacted; toldHale; Trust ±1
Jay's end-of-day thoughts	Character growth: suspicion turns to worry	loop reaches Sleep	none (reflection)
Hale's confession	Information: the backstory; character: guilt (3 Luka variants, Trust opening)	3 clues found	confessionHeard; Trust ≥4: +$100
Paul's deal	Character: calm threat; information: Paul knows the choice and Jay's Heat	carton on the counter	+$250 / $200 / $150 by Heat; paulMet
Short repeat lines	Point to the current objective (contextual help)	talk again	none

3.2 Dialogue script (as implemented)

Every line below is exported from the game's DialogueData assets, so the document and the prototype match word for word. Grey notes show a line's precondition; arrows show the player's choices and their effect.

Level 1 — Day 1 morning

Hale's briefing (first talk)

HALE: You're Jay. You're early. Good. Nobody in this town is early.

JAY: You said there was work. My rent's due in two days.

HALE: The work is simple. You seal the order at the preparation bench, carry it across the road to the counter, and take the money.

HALE: Then you come back, clean the bench, and go home. You do not open the cartons. You do not talk about the cartons.

JAY: What's in them?

HALE: An order. That is all it ever needs to be.

HALE: Two buyers today. Leo this morning: nervous, talks too much, pays. The second one comes tonight.

HALE: And Jay... my desk is not part of the job.

Corvane badge (lore pickup)

JAY: "E. Hale, Senior Chemist." So what is a senior chemist doing in a shed in Calder Flats?

Asking Hale about the badge

JAY: Corvane Industrial Chemicals... Senior chemist. That's you?

HALE: That was somebody with my name. Put it back. Or keep it. It doesn't open any doors any more.

Cracked safety award (lore)

JAY: A safety award. Turned face-down, glass cracked. Somebody didn't want to look at this.

Unpaid bills (lore)

JAY: Electricity, overdue. Water, overdue. And two red circles on the calendar. Great.

Hale, while working (repeat)

HALE: The bench, Jay. Seal it, carry it, get paid. In that order.

Leo, before the carton is on the counter

LEO: Put it on the counter first. Nothing goes hand to hand. Hale's rule, not mine.

Leo's deal

LEO: You're the new guy? Hale never hires anyone. Huh. Okay.

LEO: Is that mine? Sealed and everything. Hale's stuff is always sealed. That's why people trust it.

JAY: A hundred, right? That's what he said.

LEO: Yeah, yeah, a hundred, it's all here. Small bills, sorry. It's how they pay me.

→ *Count the money and hand over the carton.*

→ *"Who else buys from Hale?" (people notice questions: Heat +1)*

Leo's slip (optional question)

LEO: Who else? Man, I don't... look. Everybody knows Hale's stuff is the only stuff Paul's people don't touch.

JAY: Who's Paul?

LEO: Nobody. Forget I said it. Can we, uh, can we just do this?

→ *Count the money and hand over the carton.*

Leo pays

LEO: Pleasure. Tell Hale I said... nothing. Tell him nothing. Bye.

Leo, after the deal

LEO: My ride's late. Paul's people are never late. ...Forget I said that.

Hale, after the sale

HALE: Leo paid? Good. Clean the bench before you go. I don't like evidence of a good day.

Hale's news: a second buyer tonight

HALE: Clean. Good. Don't go home yet, Jay. The second order is tonight.

JAY: Who's buying?

HALE: Someone I'd rather not sell to. Come back when the street lights come on. We'll talk before he gets here.

Jay's reflection (ends Level 1)

JAY: A hundred bucks for carrying a box across a road.

JAY: Nobody makes money that easy. Nobody honest, anyway. And Hale is nervous about tonight.

Level 2 — Day 1 evening

Hale's warning about Luka

HALE: Before you seal anything: tonight is different.

HALE: Tonight's buyer is Luka. Luka is not a customer, Jay. Luka collects for someone else.

JAY: Collects for who?

HALE: For people who notice things. He'll offer you a price. He'll expect you to argue, and he'll expect you to lose.

HALE: Take his price, push for more, or send him away. It's your counter tonight. I want to see what you do with it.

JAY: And if I get it wrong?

HALE: Then we both find out what kind of man I hired.

Hale, while working (repeat)

HALE: Seal it. Carry it. Luka doesn't like waiting, and I don't like Luka.

Luka, before the carton

LUKA: The carton goes on the counter. Then we talk. That's how grown-ups do business.

Luka's deal — the meaningful choice

LUKA: So you're the old man's new boy. Look at you. Clean shoes. That won't last.

LUKA: Here's how this goes. I give you a hundred and fifty for that carton. You say thank you.

JAY: Hale said you'd say that.

LUKA: Hale says a lot of things to people who work for him. So? We doing this?

→ *Accept $150.*

→ *Push: "Two-fifty, or it goes back on the shelf."*

→ *Refuse: "Not today, Luka."*

Luka, if accepted

LUKA: Smart. Smart and quiet. People like quiet.

LUKA: Hold on. That's my phone. Don't touch anything.

Luka, if pushed

LUKA: ...Two-fifty. You've got nerve, new boy.

LUKA: Fine. But nerve gets noticed. Remember I told you that.

LUKA: Hold on. That's my phone.

Luka, if refused

LUKA: You're refusing me? Me?

LUKA: Okay. Okay. Somebody is going to hear about this, and it isn't going to be Hale.

LUKA: Hold on. That's my phone.

Luka, after the deal

LUKA: Don't look at my phone.

The "P." message (lore)

JAY: "P." ...Paul? Leo said Paul's people don't touch Hale's orders. So why is Paul asking about me?

Hale's reaction + Trust choice

HALE: He paid what he offered? Fine. Clean. Forgettable. Good. *[if accepted]*

HALE: Forgettable is how men like me stay alive out here. *[if accepted]*

HALE: Two hundred and fifty. *[if pushed]*

HALE: You made us visible, Jay. Do you understand what that means out here? It means somebody writes our names down. *[if pushed]*

HALE: You sent Luka away. *[if refused]*

HALE: ...That took more nerve than you know. More than I had at your age. *[if refused]*

HALE: Clean up. Go home. Tomorrow will be... different. *[if the phone was not read]*

→ *Tell Hale about the message from "P." (Trust +1)*

→ *Keep it to yourself. (Trust −1)*

If Jay tells Hale

JAY: Luka got a message on his phone. From someone who signs as "P."

HALE: ...Thank you for telling me. Don't say that letter inside my lab again. Clean the bench. Go home.

If Jay keeps it

JAY: Nothing else happened. He paid and left.

HALE: Nothing else. Hm. You looked at his phone, Jay. I watched you do it. Clean the bench. Go home.

Hale, afterwards

HALE: Clean the bench. Go home. Sleep, if you can.

Jay's end-of-day thought

JAY: "P." Leo went pale saying that name. Hale went pale hearing it. *[if the phone was read]*

JAY: Whoever P. is, my name is on his phone now. *[if the phone was read]*

JAY: Luka is going to tell somebody about me tonight. I just don't know who. *[if the phone was not read]*

Level 3 — Day 2 midnight

Jay wakes

JAY: Hale didn't call all day. Now it's midnight, the rent is due at dawn, and his lab is dark.

JAY: And that car has been parked out there for an hour.

The empty lab

JAY: Dr. Hale? ...His coat is still on the hook. He never goes anywhere without that coat.

JAY: Something's wrong. I should look around. Flashlight first. [F]

Ledger (clue)

JAY: Eight years. Every month, a payment to "P." Never the other way round.

Letter (clue)

JAY: Clara. His daughter? He wrote this and never sent it.

Lockbox (clue)

JAY: Four hundred and eighty thousand dollars. That's not a debt. That's a cage.

Footsteps

JAY: Footsteps. Someone's at the door.

Hale's confession

HALE: You've been straight with me since the first morning. So I'll be straight with you. *[Trust ≥ 4]*

HALE: I don't trust you, Jay. But you're all I have left tonight. *[Trust ≤ 1]*

HALE: You read them. Of course you read them. I would have.

HALE: Corvane. Eleven years ago a reactor line failed. A young engineer made the mistake. I signed the report that said it was mine.

HALE: They took my licence and gave me a settlement I could never pay. Paul bought my debt. I have been paying him in cartons ever since.

HALE: You kept things quiet with Luka. I thought that meant you understood. It means you are good at this. That frightens me. *[if accepted]*

HALE: And yesterday you squeezed his collector for an extra hundred. Paul doesn't forget a hundred dollars, Jay. He doesn't forget anything. *[if pushed]*

HALE: And yesterday you said no to Luka. I hired you so there would be someone between Paul and me. I never meant it to be someone braver than me. *[if refused]*

JAY: So why did you hire me?

HALE: Because tonight's order goes out in person. Paul is coming himself.

HALE: Seal it. Carry it. Be polite. Then go home and forget his face.

HALE: And take this. A hundred, for your rent. Don't argue with me. *[Trust ≥ 4]*

→ *Take Hale's $100.*

→ *"Keep it. You'll need it more than me."*

Hale (repeat)

HALE: Seal it, Jay. Before he gets impatient. Men like Paul are very patient right up until they aren't.

Paul, before the carton

PAUL: Take your time. Put it on the counter when you are ready. I'm a patient man.

Paul's deal

PAUL: Luka says you're easy to work with. Easy is useful. *[if accepted]*

PAUL: You squeezed my man for an extra hundred. Bold. Expensive. *[if pushed]*

PAUL: The kid who said no to Luka. I respect a man who knows his price. *[if refused]*

PAUL: I'm Paul. You've heard the name, I think. Most people hear it before they meet me.

PAUL: Your name reached me twice this week, Jay. Loud men cost me money. One-fifty for the carton. *[Heat ≥ 3]*

PAUL: Two hundred for the carton. *[Heat 2]*

PAUL: Nobody has mentioned you. Quiet men are rare. Two-fifty for the carton. *[Heat ≤ 1]*

PAUL: And something else. For you.

JAY: Something else?

→ *Take the $150 / $200 / $250 (only the price matching Heat is shown)*

→ *"What do you want with Hale?"*

"What do you want with Hale?"

PAUL: Hale owes me. Hale will always owe me. That isn't about you.

PAUL: Unless you want it to be.

→ *Take the $150 / $200 / $250 (only the price matching Heat is shown)*

Paul takes the carton

PAUL: Good. Count it if you like. I never miss.

4. Level Descriptions

Level 1 — First Delivery (Act 1 · Day 1 morning)

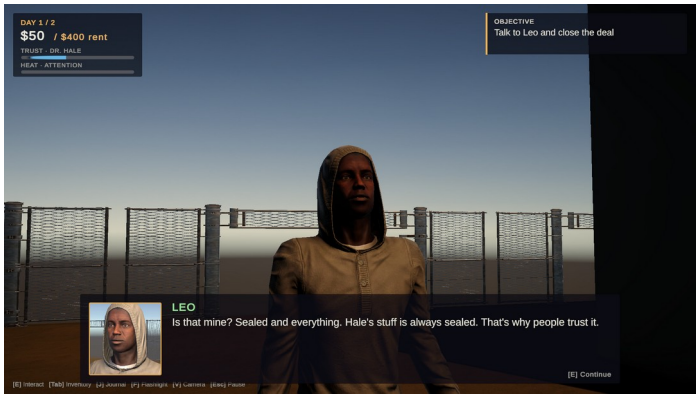
Narrative role: Introduces Jay, Hale and the rules of the work, and plants the mystery of Hale's past.

Narrative moments: Opening cutscene; Hale's briefing ("two buyers today"); sealing the first carton; Leo's deal (optional question reveals "Paul"); Hale's news of a second order tonight; Jay's reflection.

Environmental storytelling: Eviction notice and a calendar with two red circles on Jay's wall; unpaid bills on his desk; Corvane badge and a face-down cracked safety award in the lab; dust and stains showing the lab was once busier. Street lamps switch off one by one as the sun rises.

Unique mechanic and gate: First hand-off: carry, place on the counter, a tutorial deal. Gate: reporting the clean bench to Hale brings his news of a second order; Jay's reflection sets act1Complete → "Later that day" recap → Level 2 (no sleep: two customers on Day 1).

Player objectives (as shown in the tracker): Cross the road and talk to Dr. Hale → Seal Leo's order → Carry the carton to the counter → Talk to Leo and close the deal → Clean the bench → Tell Dr. Hale the bench is clean.



Level 1 (Day 1 morning): Leo at the counter in the morning light.

Level 2 — The Middleman (Act 2 · Day 1 evening)

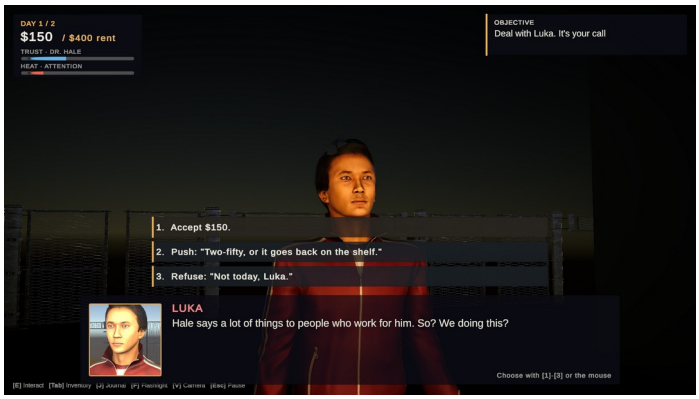
Narrative role: The second customer of the same day raises the stakes: a buyer who pushes back and reveals a bigger player.

Narrative moments: Hale's warning; Luka's deal (the meaningful choice); Luka's reaction; the "P." message; Hale's reaction (three variants) and the choice to tell him about "P."; reflection.

Environmental storytelling: Fresh tyre tracks and oil where a car waited; cigarette butts by the counter; the street lamps flicker on mid-deal as the colour grade shifts to orange, and a warm work lamp beside the counter lights Luka's face.

Unique mechanic and gate: Choice with visible consequences on Cash, Trust and Heat; refusing sends the carton back to the shelf. Luka's phone buzzes on the counter until the player reads it. Gate: act2Complete after sleep → recap (three variants) → Level 3, the next day.

Player objectives (as shown in the tracker): Talk to Dr. Hale before tonight's order → Seal Luka's order → Carry it to the counter → Deal with Luka (your call) → Check the phone Luka left → Tell Dr. Hale how it went (and whether to mention "P.") → Clean → Sleep.



Level 2 (Day 1 evening): Luka's offer at dusk, lit by the counter work lamp — the meaningful choice, with each option's consequence spelled out.

Level 3 — The Big Buyer (Act 3 · Day 2 midnight)

Narrative role: Pays off every thread: Hale's past, the choice, Trust and Heat, and Paul.

Narrative moments: Jay wakes at midnight with the rent due at dawn; empty lab; three clues; Hale's confession (Trust decides how much he says and whether he gives Jay $100); Paul's arrival and offer (Heat sets his price); ending cutscene.

Environmental storytelling: Hale's lab fixtures are off for the first time ("The lights are off at Hale's") and only come on when he walks back in; Hale's coat on the hook, forced lockbox, headlights at the end of the road, the counter work lamp lighting Paul's face, a warm light spilling from the lab doorway in the final shot; cold blue grade.

Unique mechanic and gate: Flashlight search for three clues (counter-based trigger) before Hale returns; the lab is silent until his footsteps and the hum of the lights return. Gate: paulMet → ending cutscene → end screen.

Player objectives (as shown in the tracker): Find out why Hale's lab is dark → Search the lab with your flashlight: ledger, letter, lockbox → Dr. Hale is back, talk to him → Seal Paul's order → Carry it to the counter → Meet Paul.



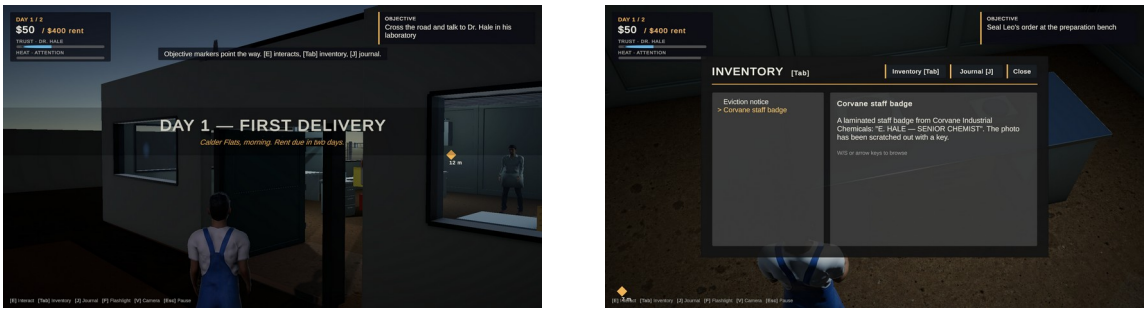
Level 3 (Day 2 midnight): Paul at the counter; his price for the carton depends on Heat.

5. UI Design Concept

Element	Design	Story information it delivers
Dialogue box	Speaker name in the character's colour, portrait, typewriter text, up to three numbered choices.	Who is speaking and what they want; choices state their consequence in plain words ("Accept $150").
Objective tracker	Top-right panel with a "NEW OBJECTIVE" flash and an on-screen marker with distance.	The current story goal, derived from the story state, so it never goes out of sync.
Status indicators	Day 1/2, Cash with the $400 rent goal, Trust (Dr. Hale) and Heat bars; a short message the first time either crosses a threshold.	The core conflict at a glance: money against loyalty and attention. The meters matter: Trust changes what Hale says and gives, Heat changes what Paul pays.
Inventory [Tab] / Journal [J]	Notebook with tabs: collected lore items and written clues.	Environmental storytelling the player chose to discover (badge, phone message, ledger, letter).
Prompts & toasts	Contextual "[E] ..." prompt; short messages for feedback.	Signs & feedback (lecture): every interaction confirms what happened.
Menus & loading	Main menu over the live world at dusk with its own theme; Chapters (Day 1 morning, Day 1 evening, Day 2 in story order, unlocked as reached); pause (resume, restart day, settings); loading recap between levels; end screen.	Narrative progress markers: each recap summarises consequences and the next stakes.

Design follows the lecture's UI principles: visual hierarchy (objective and dialogue strongest), contrast (off-white on dark translucent panels, one amber accent), consistency (one font, one panel style, one interact key [E]) and contextual prompts with progressive disclosure (a prompt appears only when something can be used). It avoids the two Week 7 UI mistakes: feedback is not only on the HUD (Signs & Feedback also come from the lamps, the buzzing phone, the lab hum and the camera), and the HUD never shows information irrelevant to the current task (the marker shows only the current objective; the HUD and prompts hide during dialogue and cutscenes). Motion follows the motion-graphics principles: responsive (text can be completed with one press), intentional (the new-objective flash leads the eye) and consistent. Subtitles accompany every line and their size is adjustable.

Camera (Week 7 "Virtual Camera"): first-person by default with a third-person follow view [V], avatar-relative WASD and mouse-look controls, and a Cinemachine dialogue camera that frames the speaker. For comfort there is no head bob or camera shake, cuts between views ease in and out over 0.45 s, cutscene shots drift slowly, and mouse sensitivity and invert-Y are in Settings.



Left: HUD — status (day, cash vs rent, trust, heat), objective tracker, marker, tutorial hint and chapter card. Right: inventory with lore descriptions (Tab).

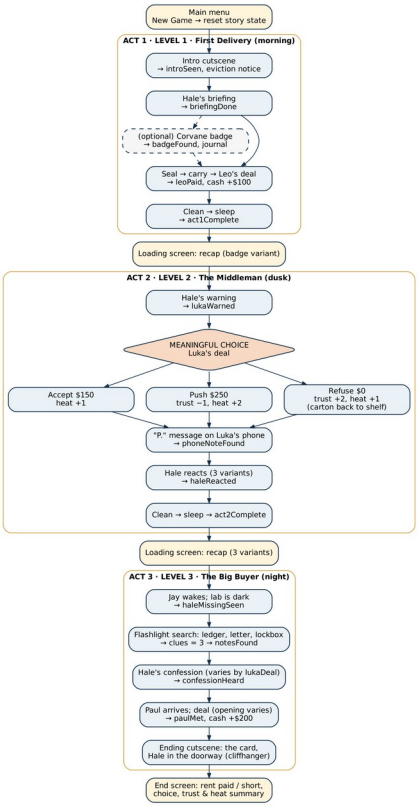
6. Storyline Implementation Plan

6.1 Story beat table

#	Beat	Level	Trigger	UI shown	State change
1	Eviction notice	L1	Intro cutscene (auto)	Subtitles	introSeen, item
2	Meet Hale	L1	Talk [E]	Dialogue + portrait	briefingDone
3	Corvane badge	L1	Pick up	Inventory + journal	badgeFound
4	Seal first carton	L1	Bench [E]	Prompt, toast	cartonSealed

#	Beat	Level	Trigger	UI shown	State change
5	Leo's deal	L1	Counter + talk	Dialogue choices	leoPaid, +$100; asking: Heat +1
6	Second order tonight	L1→L2	Talk after cleaning	Dialogue; evening recap	haleEvening, act1Complete
7	Hale's warning	L2	Talk [E]	Dialogue	lukaWarned
8	Dusk falls	L2	Carton delivered	Lamps, grade	lukaArrived
9	THE CHOICE	L2	Dialogue choice	Choices + bars	lukaDeal, trust/heat
10	"P." message	L2	Inspect phone	Journal	phoneNoteFound
11	Hale reacts; tell him?	L2→L3	Choice; sleep	Choices + Trust bar	toldHale, Trust ±1, act2Complete
12	Dark lab	L3	Enter zone	Inner monologue	haleMissingSeen
13	Search	L3	3 pickups	Inventory	clues=3 → notesFound
14	Confession	L3	Talk [E]	Variant by choice + Trust	confessionHeard; Trust ≥4: +$100
15	Paul	L3	Counter + talk	Variant by choice + Heat	paulMet, + $250/200/150
16	The card	L3	Ending cutscene	Cutscene, end screen	endingSeen

6.2 Flowchart, story flags and dialogue format



Foldback: the choice branches in Act 2 and reconverges at Paul; consequences carry forward.

Story flags and variables

introSeen / briefingDone / badgeFound: Opening cutscene seen; Hale's briefing done; badge collected (optional).

cartonSealed / leoPaid / haleEvening / act1Complete: First order sealed; Leo paid; Hale announced the evening order; morning over → load Level 2 (same day).

lukaWarned / lukaDealt / lukaDeal: Warning heard; choice made; text value accepted / pushed / refused.

phoneNoteFound / haleReacted / toldHale / act2Complete: "P." clue found; Hale's reaction heard; Jay told Hale about "P."; Day 1 over → load Level 3 (Day 2).

haleMissingSeen / clues (int) / notesFound: Entered the dark lab; clues found 0–3; all three found → Hale returns.

confessionHeard / paulMet / endingSeen: Confession done; Paul paid → ending cutscene; end screen reached.

cash · trust · heat · day (ints): HUD values; trust and heat clamped 0–5; rent goal $400. Trust ≥4: Hale confesses fully and gives $100 (haleGift); Trust ≤1: he holds back. Heat ≤1: Paul pays $250; 2: $200; ≥3: $150.

Dialogue format: ScriptableObjects

Dialogue is stored as ScriptableObjects (DialogueData): each asset holds lines (speaker profile, text, optional conditions), choices (text, conditions, effects, loop action, payment, follow-up conversation) and completion effects — the lecture's dialogue tree with preconditions and actions. Characters keep a prioritised list of conversations; the first whose preconditions pass is played. ScriptableObjects were chosen because they are native to Unity, editable in the Inspector without code, need no extra package (unlike Ink or Yarn) and keep story content out of game logic, avoiding the brief's common mistake of hard-coded dialogue.

7. Art and Aesthetic Style

Visual style: grounded realism in Unity URP — photoscanned CC0 props, realistic humans, physically based materials, a per-act colour grade (warm sunrise, orange dusk, cold blue

night), white balance, contrast, bloom and vignette set per act in URP volumes, and worn surfaces (stains, oil, tyre tracks) so every space looks used.

Colour script: amber marks safety and story UI; the desert is warm in Act 1; Act 2 shifts to orange as the lamps turn on; Act 3 is blue-black, lit only by the flashlight, the street lamps, the warm counter work lamp and the warm doorway in the final shot.

Aesthetics (lecture): clarity (one amber accent marks what matters), satisfaction (every action answers with sound, light or text) and style (worn, quiet realism). Of the eight kinds of fun the game targets narrative and discovery first, with light challenge in the choice.

Audio follows the Week 7 sound-design roles. Theme (reinforces the experience): an original score in D minor, written for the game — a slow theme for the opening, a darker variant for the ending that stops on an unresolved chord (the cliffhanger), and a looping menu theme.

Gameplay cues and feedback: Luka's phone buzzes on the counter until it is read; the lab lights hum, so the dark lab on the last night is silent until Hale's footsteps and the hum return; Paul's car idles at the end of the road. Interface: a Kenney chime when a conversation opens and an impact sound for placing cartons and confirming choices. All sounds are attached to story events and use 3D attenuation.



Colour script: lit lab in the morning (Hale's briefing), orange dusk with the lamps on (Luka's deal), cold blue midnight in the dark lab (Day 2).

8. Story in the Prototype (video timestamps)

Timestamps refer to the submitted 2:53 video (VGD Assignment 3.mp4): real-time footage of the final build, cut to the story beats and features with on-screen captions. The unedited 12-minute playthrough of every chapter is in the repository (Video/Jay_A_Career_Assignment3_Prototype.mp4).

Time	Story beat shown in the video
00:00	Title card
00:03	Main menu · Chapters list in story order
00:12	Loading screen with a story recap
00:17	Opening cutscene (Timeline, Cinemachine, music, subtitles)

Time	Story beat shown in the video
00:26	Dr. Hale's briefing · dialogue box with name, portrait and typewriter text
00:37	Lore item: Hale's badge picked up into the inventory
00:48	Leo's deal · optional questions raise Heat
01:00	Day 1 evening · the second customer is announced
01:11	Dusk · street lamps and the counter work lamp
01:17	Luka's deal · the meaningful choice (accept $150 / push $250 / refuse)
01:32	Sound cue · the buzzing phone leads to the "P." message
01:40	Trust choice · tell Hale about "P." or keep it
01:52	Day 2 midnight · flashlight search: ledger, letter, lockbox
02:04	Low Trust · Hale's reaction ("I don't trust you, Jay")
02:15	High Heat · Paul's lower offer ($150)
02:33	Ending cutscene · the card
02:43	End screen · rent, Trust and Heat outcomes

9. Implementation Notes, Revisions and Credits

9.1 Scripts

Script	Responsibility
StoryStateManager	Flags, integers and texts across scenes; OnFlagSet event; level snapshot for restart.
DialogueData / CharacterProfile	ScriptableObject conversations and speaker profiles (name, colour, portrait).
DialogueManager	Typewriter dialogue box, choices, follow-ups, effects, play-once handling.
ObjectiveManager	Derives the current objective from the story state.
StoryTrigger / LoreItem	Fire-once beats (zone, start, condition) and interactive lore objects.
LevelDirector	Per-level pacing, loop-to-story mapping, story-driven time of day, gated transitions.
CutsceneController	Timeline + Cinemachine cutscenes, subtitles, hold-to-skip, finish actions.
LevelTransitionManager / LoadingScreenController	Story-gated scene loading with recap screen.
StoryHUD / NotebookUI / Pause / End / SettingsManager	HUD, inventory & journal, pause and end screens, saved settings.
StreetLampController	Lamps switch on at dusk and off at dawn, one by one, with a flicker.
StoryAudioCue / AudioFadeOut	Looping 3D sound cues that play only while story conditions hold (phone, lab hum); score fades across scenes.
MainMenuController	New Game, Chapters (the three levels in story order, unlocked as reached), Settings, Credits, Quit.
JayPlayerController / JayGameManager (extended)	Movement, single [E] interaction, delivery loop raising story events.

Verification: an automated playthrough (Assignment3AutoPilot) plays the game from the main menu to the end screen through each Luka branch and checks every beat, flag, cash/trust/heat value, payment, sound cue, menu chapter and transition: 233 of 233 checks pass across the three branches, and the recorded run passes 75 of 75 (reports in the repository under Deliverables/Evidence/Assignment3).

9.2 Revision log (revisions 2–3, 5–6 November 2026)

Area	Change
Story structure (rev. 3)	Two days instead of three: Day 1 has two customers (Leo in the morning, Luka in the evening) and Day 2 is the big deal with Paul. Level 1 now ends with Hale announcing the evening order instead of sleep; rent is due in two days.

Area	Change
Trust and Heat (rev. 3)	The meters now matter beyond the Luka choice: asking Leo about other buyers raises Heat; telling Hale about "P." or keeping it changes Trust. High Trust makes Hale confess fully and give Jay $100; low Trust makes him hold back. Paul pays $250, $200 or $150 depending on Heat. A message appears when a threshold is crossed, and the end screen explains both.
Counter lamp (rev. 3)	A practical work lamp beside the counter (warm key light on the buyer's face plus a soft fill) makes Luka at dusk and Paul at midnight readable.
Dialogue	Every line now reveals information, reveals character or breaks up the monotony. Rewritten: Hale's opening and his warning about Luka; Leo's greeting, waiting and before-delivery lines; Jay's end-of-day and midnight thoughts (the end-of-day thought now reacts to whether the "P." message was read).
Music	Original score for the opening and closing cutscenes (brief Step 7), the main menu and the end screen; the ending score carries over into the end screen and fades out.
Story sound cues	Phone buzz (leads to the clue, stops once read), lab-light hum (silent in the dark lab on the last night), Hale's footsteps, Paul's idling car — driven by story state.
Menu flow	Chapters screen: the three levels in story order, each unlocked the first time it is reached.
Lighting and polish	Hale's lab lights on during the Day 1 levels and dark on the last night until he returns; interaction prompt hidden during dialogue; credits corrected.
Verification	Automated playthrough extended with checks for the score, the menu chapters, the phone cue and the dark lab; all three branches re-run.

9.3 Requirements checklist

Brief requirement	Where
≥3 playable story levels, menu, intro and ending	MainMenu, L1, L2, L3, Ending; Timeline intro and ending (§4, §8)
≥3 narrative moments per level; story-driven objectives	Beat table §6.1; ObjectiveManager
Story state, meaningful choice, gated transitions	StoryStateManager; Luka choice; LevelDirector (§6)
Environmental storytelling; interactive narrative elements	Lore items, decals, lamps, props (§4)
Dialogue box with name and portrait; objectives; status; inventory; journal	§5
≥6 commented scripts, ≥2 narrative	24 commented C# scripts in Scripts/Story, 9 dedicated to narrative (§9.1)
Start menu: start, levels in narrative order, exit/restart	New Game, Chapters, Quit; pause menu Restart Level (§5)
Cutscenes with camera, music and subtitles; skippable; set a flag	Intro and ending: Timeline + Cinemachine + score + subtitles; hold Space to skip; introSeen / endingSeen
Links, timestamps, file name	Title page; §8 (submission video timestamps)

9.4 Credits

• Environment and props: Poly Haven models and textures (CC0); ModKit v1.2 modules (CC0); original Blender models of the lab and bedroom (A2).
• Dr. Hale and Jay: MakeHuman / MPFB humans (CC0) with original animation clips; sounds: Kenney Impact and Interface Sounds (CC0) and original synthesised ambience.
• Music and story sound cues (3 themes, phone, car, lab hum, footsteps): original, synthesised for this project by Tools/synth_story_audio.py.
• Leo, Luka and Paul: Microsoft Rocketbox avatars (MIT licence) — Male_Adult_18, Male_Adult_10, Business_Male_04.
• Engine and packages: Unity 6000.3.24f1, URP 17.3, Cinemachine 3.1.5, Timeline, TextMeshPro, Input System, Unity Recorder.
• Decals, calendar and eviction-notice textures: generated procedurally for this project.
• All characters, places, companies and products are fictional. No real chemistry is shown or described.